

TV NEWS



THEN AND NOW: Indira Gandhi at the DD studio in Delhi (above); bank of monitors in Aaj Tak's control room (left)

viewers' attention and chasing TRPs (television rating points). Satellite news television is the impatient, impertinent elder child of globalisation. Baptised by Kargil and terror strikes, it snatched some of the spotlight away from its younger sibling, the entertainment channel. It even adopted some of its mannerisms and it's not just the heavily-made-up anchors. From serial bombings to superstar flings, news is delivered with the same breathless urgency. Till July this year, average TRPs for news viewership were 7.9 per cent, compared to 5.2 in 2004.

Forget the stale Tulsis and Parvatis, news TV is a fast and furious medium that demands celebrities 24x7. A struggling starlet Rakhi

Sawant is given the kiss of life by a popstar and becomes TV's first female superstar. Its first child star who fell into a disused tubewell and shot into national consciousness may well grow into adulthood and thank his parents for naming him for royalty. News channels have tapped into history and mythology, superstition and sorcery. The astrologer has replaced the psephologist and there is a new aggressive breed of TV shark, the small-town stringer who, for a monthly lump sum, will capture the weird and the wonderful and even, occasionally, stage the news. It is here that "making news" gets a whole new dubious meaning. The sting operation, a weapon of last resort, is used in sensational first-strikes and sometimes crosses the line, like it did when a spurious sting purportedly showed a Delhi school teacher pimping children of her own school.

Yet even in this mind-numbing cacophony, there is a comforting thought of the accountability enforced by angry and breathless anchors. Jessica

Lal and Priyadarshini Mattoo, two victims killed by two rich scions at the dawn of news television, finally got justice, a decade later, when the medium was at its apex. But for those worried about the mayhem caused by television news itself, this revolution, too, is at the mercy of a small gadget: the remote control. ■

R. BASU, acting D-G of Doordarshan, 1994

"The DD staff has traditionally been conservative and defensive, taking the least dangerous option."